

After Action Review:

Armenia Crisis

October 2020 - October 2024



*Empowered lives.
Resilient nations.*



©UN Armenia_avedisian

Contents

LIST OF ACRONYMS.....	2
1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY	4
2. COUNTRY SITUATION AND CONTEXT	6
3. METHODOLOGY	7
4. ANALYSIS OF THE UNDP RESPONSE	7
4.1 TIMELINE OF CRISIS EVENTS AND RESPONSE ACTIONS	7
4.2 UNDP IN-COUNTRY STRUCTURE AND RESPONSE CAPACITY	10
4.3 UNDP CORPORATE RESPONSE MECHANISMS	10
4.3.1 DEPLOYMENT OF EXPERTS	11
4.3.2 PROGRAMMATIC RESPONSE SUPPORT	11
4.3.3 OPERATIONAL RESPONSE SUPPORT	12
4.3.4 COORDINATION SUPPORT	12
4.3.5 COMMUNICATION SUPPORT	13
4.3.6 RESOURCE MOBILIZATION SUPPORT	13
5. FINDINGS AND RECOMMENDATIONS	15
5.1 KEY FINDINGS AND LESSONS LEARNED	15
5.2 ACTIONABLE RECOMMENDATIONS	16
ANNEX 1: LIST OF CRISIS MEETINGS	18
ANNEX 2: CRISIS ALLOCATIONS	19
ANNEX 3: CRISIS DEPLOYMENTS	20
ANNEX 4: LIST OF INTERVIEWEES	21
ANNEX 5: MATRIX OF MAIN FINDINGS AND RECOMMENDATIONS	22

List of Acronyms

AA	Associate Administrator
ARM	Armenia
AZE	Azerbaijan
BERA	Bureau for External Relations and Advocacy
BMS	Bureau of Management Services
CERF	Central Emergency Response Fund
CMST	Country Management Support Team
CO	Country Office
DCO	Development Coordination Office
DPPA	UN Department of Political and Peacebuilding Affairs
DPPA	UN Department of Political and Peacebuilding Affairs
EU	European Union
FW	Funding Window
GoA	Government of Armenia
HQ	Headquarters
HR	Human Resources
IMO	Information Management Officer
IRH	Istanbul Regional Hub
MIRA	Multi Sector Initial Rapid Assessment
MLSA	Ministry of Labour and Social Affairs
NGO	Non-Governmental Organization
NK	Nagorno-Karabakh
OCHA	United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs
OHCHR	United Nations Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights
PDA	Peace and Development Advisor
PDNA	Post-Disaster Needs Assessment
PSG	Programme Support Group
RBEC	Regional Bureau for Europe and the Commonwealth of Independent States
RBEC	Regional Bureau for Europe and the Commonwealth of Independent States
RC	Resident Coordinator
RCO	Resident Coordinator's Office
RNA	Rapid Needs Assessment
RPBA	Recovery and Peacebuilding Assessment
SBP	Standby Partner
TRAC	Target for Resource Assignment from the Core
UK	United Kingdom
UN	United Nations
UNBOA	United Nations Board of Auditors

UNDP	United Nations Development Programme
UNDSS	United Nations Department of Safety and Security
UNDSS	United Nations Department of Safety and Security
UNHCR	United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees
UNICEF	United Nations Children's Fund
UNV	United Nations Volunteer
USD	United States Dollars

1. Executive Summary

Between 2020 and 2024, Armenia experienced a prolonged and complex crisis shaped by renewed conflict with Azerbaijan, the COVID 19 pandemic, political instability, and natural disasters, including major flooding in 2024. These overlapping events created a highly sensitive and restrictive operating environment for UNDP, compounded by geopolitical dynamics and the requirement for UNDP to support both Armenia and Azerbaijan simultaneously.

UNDP activated its corporate crisis response early. A Crisis Board declared an L2 crisis on 2 October 2020, escalating Armenia to L3 on 2 November 2020. Over the course of the crisis, 45 CMST meetings and three Crisis Board meetings were held. The Programme Support Group (PSG) was established in May 2021 to provide programmatic review and support, filling a gap where CMST meetings, often highly political, could not fully address operational and programmatic issues.

UNDP Armenia demonstrated strong crisis-response capacity, adjusting projects, mobilizing CERF, Funding Window, and TRAC3 resources, and engaging donors. Despite a modest internal allocation of USD 1.75 million, the CO mobilized or repurposed over USD 27 million from external donors. UNDP's role in livelihoods, housing, social protection, mine action, and resilience was recognized by national partners, including contributions to the 2023 Refugee Response Plan and 2024 flood response through MIRA and PDNA processes.

Sixteen experts were deployed through SURGE, ExpRes, Standby Partners, and UNV modalities. While deployments were timely and reinforced capacity, the ExpRes roster lacked adequate profiles for early recovery in politically sensitive, middle income settings. Communications support was deployed early through a regional crisis communications expert and messaging protocols; however, the CO still faced insufficient communications capacity, including gaps in web updates, crisis visibility, strategic targeting, and unified narrative issues highlighted in the UN BOA report.

Corporate mechanisms functioned throughout the crisis but had limitations. CMST meetings were frequent and valuable for HQ but offered limited added value for CO needs. Balancing simultaneous support to Armenia and Azerbaijan introduced operational constraints due to political sensitivities. Coordination structures evolved over time, including use of the South Caucasus Working Group led by DPPA. Attempts to initiate an RPBA did not proceed due to lack of a formal government request. Programmatic interventions included housing assessments and planning with MLSA, livelihoods programs for refugee women and refugee led businesses, infrastructure rehabilitation, social cohesion efforts, mine-action assessments, and beehive and solar heater initiatives supported through Funding Window resources.

Operational challenges were influenced by the COVID 19 context; although Armenia managed required activities, institutional special measures (fast tracked procurement or HR) were not activated early, limiting initial flexibility. Such measures have since been institutionalized.

Key findings emphasize:

- the catalytic effect of seed funding;
- the value of expert deployments but gaps in suitable profiles;
- insufficient crisis communications capacity;
- the need for more efficient corporate coordination mechanisms;
- missed opportunities for early special measures;

- and the lack of preparedness for the scale and speed of the 2023 refugee influx despite contextual constraints.

Recommendations include strengthening resource mobilization strategies and crisis communications, diversifying rosters for politically sensitive settings, streamlining coordination mechanisms, integrating political guidance earlier, ensuring immediate use of special measures, and institutionalizing contingency planning and preparedness between acute crisis phases.

2. Country situation and context

The longstanding conflict between Armenia and Azerbaijan over the Nagorno-Karabakh region dates to the dissolution of the Soviet Union. Following a six-year war from 1988 to 1994, the two countries agreed to a truce, but tensions and ceasefire violations continued. In September 2020, the most intense fighting since the early 1990s reignited. Between 2020 and 2024, Armenia faced a series of overlapping crises, armed conflict, health emergencies, political instability, and natural disasters, that placed considerable strain on communities, institutions, and national systems. The evolving crisis landscape, marked by escalations related to the Armenia–Azerbaijan conflict, the COVID-19 pandemic, and environmental shocks such as the 2024 floods, created a highly complex and politically sensitive operating environment. A detailed timeline of key crisis events and UNDP’s response actions is provided in Section 4.1. Together these events formed a poly-crisis, requiring sustained, coordinated, and adaptive support across both humanitarian and development sectors.

The Armenia–Azerbaijan context created a uniquely complex and politically sensitive operating environment for UNDP, requiring simultaneous support to two COs on opposite sides of a longstanding conflict. This dual engagement demanded discretion, neutrality, and close coordination across UNDP structures at the country, regional, and headquarters levels, as well as the UN Department of Political and Peacebuilding Affairs (DPPA) engagement for political guidance and advice due to the political complexity of the situation. Due to sensitivities¹, the Government of Armenia requested all coordination be routed through UNDP HQ, restricting the Istanbul Regional Hub (IRH) from conducting field missions and requiring remote technical support instead.

Additionally, these dynamics placed considerable psychological pressure on staff in both COs, underscoring the need for accessible stress counselling and psychosocial support, to be delivered in-country or remotely via the UNDP Security Office or United Nations Department of Safety and Security (UNDSS). Overall, the context shaped the response architecture, highlighting the need for flexibility, principled engagement, and sustained coordination in politically charged settings.

¹ Türkiye’s political relationship with Armenia has long been shaped by historical grievances, regional conflicts, and shifting geopolitical dynamics, particularly due to Türkiye’s strategic partnership with Azerbaijan, which has deepened following the 2020 Nagorno-Karabakh war.

3. Methodology

Given the complex and evolving crisis context, a mixed-methods approach was used to capture both internal and external dimensions of UNDP's response. The review draws primarily on qualitative insights, complemented by available data sources, to provide an overall assessment of UNDP Armenia CO's strategic, operational, and programmatic performance during this period.

Data sources include:

- **Desk review** of key documents such as meeting summaries, project and allocation reports, deployment records, and situation analyses (2020–2024);
- **Key Informant Interviews** with Crisis Bureau, Regional Bureau for Europe and the Commonwealth of Independent States (RBEC) staff, including former senior leadership from UNDP Armenia;
- **2024 UNBOA Audit results**, covering activities throughout December 2024;
- **Internal input** from UNDP Armenia CO teams to capture operational insights and institutional learning.

Findings and conclusions were validated by UNDP Armenia CO and the RBEC to ensure accuracy, relevance, and alignment with the overall response.

4. Analysis of the UNDP Response

4.1 Timeline of crisis events and response actions

Between September and November 2020, a large-scale escalation between Armenia and Azerbaijan took place, during which Azerbaijan regained control over seven districts and parts of Nagorno-Karabakh. In response, on 2 October 2020, the first Crisis Board was convened, declaring an L2 crisis for Armenia and Azerbaijan.

On 2 November 2020, the second Crisis Board reassessed the situation and escalated Armenia to a L3 crisis. A third Crisis Board was held on 20 November 2020. A trilateral statement between Armenia, Azerbaijan, and Russia was signed in November 2020, putting an end to large-scale hostilities.

On 11 May 2021, the Programme Support Group was established by the Crisis Management Support Team to carry out programmatic review, manage risks, and identify issues for escalation to CMST and the Crisis Board. This was followed by the introduction of additional procedures for risk management, oversight, and guidance on 25 June 2021. The Standard Operating Procedure for South Caucasus Crisis Response was approved on 15 September 2021.

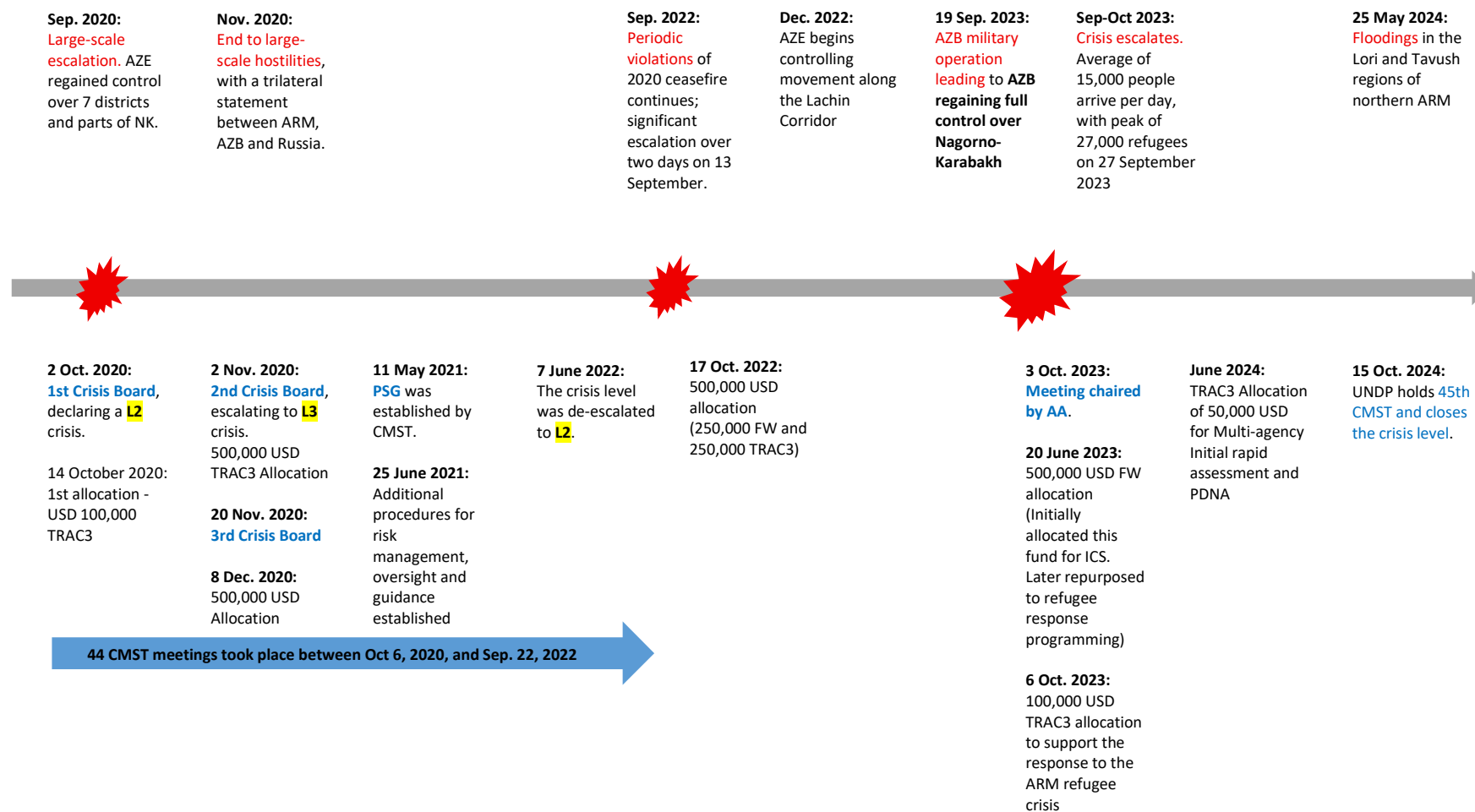
Although the 2020 ceasefire continued to be periodically violated, there were no major conflicts between the two countries. Therefore, the crisis level was de-escalated to L2 on 7 June 2022. However, shortly after that, a notable escalation occurred over two days on 13 September 2022. During this period between October 6, 2020, and September 22, 2022, 44 CMST meetings were organized.

In December 2022, Azerbaijan began controlling movement along the Lachin Corridor, and by April 2023, a checkpoint had been established. Azerbaijan military operation started on 19 September 2023 led to Azerbaijan regaining full control over Nagorno-Karabakh. This resulted in a large-scale

refugee crisis, with an average of 15,000 individuals arriving to Armenia per day, peaking at 27,000 people on 27 September 2023 (over 115,000 refugees arrived in Armenia within just 10 days, equivalent to around 4% of its population). On 3 October 2023, a meeting chaired by the UNDP Associate Administrator was held, during which it was agreed that the L2 Crisis level was adequate to the scale of the crisis.

On 25 May 2024, severe flooding occurred in the Lori and Tavush regions of northern Armenia, affecting over 41,000 people. On 15 October 2024, UNDP held the final, 45th, CMST meeting and formally closed the crisis level.

Timeline of crisis events and response actions



4.2 UNDP in-country structure and response capacity

The Armenia CO demonstrated strong crisis response capacity, quickly mobilizing emergency funding (CERF, Funding Windows, TRAC 3, bilateral donor funding – Japan, Norway, Serbia, Sweden, etc.), adjusting ongoing projects, engaging stakeholders, and attracting new donors. Strong vision - Armenia's Refugee Crisis: Resilience for All - UNDP Offer to support refugees, host communities and Government of Armenia – was put in place by the CO in consultation with RBEC and CB.

The transition from emergency to recovery was handled efficiently, with a clear, structured approach that reflected the CO's ability to operate across the emergency–development nexus and prioritize resilience from the outset. UNDP's engagement in humanitarian-related activities, shaped by successive national crises, drew mixed reactions from other UN agencies. While concerns were raised about mandate overlaps, coordination burdens, and funding competition, agencies also acknowledged the value of early UNDP involvement in crisis settings, particularly in resilience-focused efforts and in leveraging development resources for humanitarian impact.

One of the challenges in UNDP's response was limited institutional readiness to effectively operate within a humanitarian context in a middle-income country. While not unprecedented, this was among the first large-scale crises in the region in several years, and it exposed initial hesitation and ambiguity around UNDP's leadership role in early recovery. This underscored the need for clearer guidance and preparedness in navigating complex, multi-dimensional crisis settings in similar contexts moving forward.

The CO's effectiveness was supported by strong partnerships at all levels, a broad portfolio in inclusion and governance, and staff expertise in needs assessment, rapid response design, and resource mobilization. In 2023-2024, UNDP Armenia played a key role in the design and implementation of the joint Refugee Response Plan, contributing to the shelter and non-food items sector as well as resilience programming.

The CO engagement from the first days of the refugee crisis was acknowledged and appreciated by the national partners at all levels, donors and, most importantly, refugees and host communities.

4.3 UNDP corporate response mechanisms

The Armenia response highlighted both the strengths and limitations of UNDP's corporate crisis mechanisms. While structures such as Crisis Board, CMST, and the PSG were activated in a timely manner and provided strategic and technical direction, they did not always adequately reflect the contextual needs and evolving priorities in the country. For example, between 2020 and 2024, a total of 45 CMSTs were convened. While these meetings were valuable for HQ colleagues in understanding the dynamic and the constantly evolving situations on the ground in the respective countries, it can be argued that they offered limited added value from the perspective of the COs. This underscores the importance of ensuring that corporate tools remain agile, context-sensitive, and closely informed by CO realities, while serving not only the HQ but also the CO needs.

4.3.1 Deployment of experts

As part of the response in Armenia, a total of 16 experts were deployed to support the CO. This included four SURGE Advisors, ten ExpRes consultants, one Standby Partner secondee (SBP), and one United Nations Volunteer (UNV). A full list of deployments is provided in Annex 3. These deployments were carefully coordinated with both the Armenia CO to ensure that expert profiles aligned with the specific needs identified on the ground.

In 2020 alone, nine experts supported the initial phase of the crisis response, bringing valuable expertise in conflict prevention, early recovery, and security, amongst others. Their contributions significantly enhanced UNDP Armenia's programmatic capacity in these areas. While the deployments were timely, the ExpRes roster had limited profiles tailored to early recovery in politically sensitive, middle-income settings. Nonetheless, the SURGE support proved instrumental in strengthening the CO's ability to respond effectively and adaptively in a highly complex and evolving context.

4.3.2 Programmatic response support

UNDP Armenia's programmatic response focused on addressing urgent needs across housing, livelihoods, mine action, and disaster recovery.

With TRAC 3 fund allocations, the Armenia CO supported the Government of Armenia (GoA) in addressing critical housing and employment needs identified in a Rapid Needs Assessment (RNA). At the request of the Ministry of Labour and Social Affairs (MLSA), UNDP helped design a Comprehensive Social Housing Development Concept and Action Plan. This included assessments of housing vulnerability, existing residential stock, infrastructure, and a results framework. The CO also supported donor coordination efforts in the housing sector and implemented a livelihoods programme targeting refugee women and women-headed households. In the Armavir region, the local NGO Oxygen was contracted to provide business training, mentoring, and startup grants of up to \$5,000. Implementation of the refugee response was challenged by shifting government priorities, delays in validating key assessments due to limited partners capacity, a lack of detailed data to guide targeted interventions, and the high mobility of refugee populations, which complicated beneficiary tracking and service delivery.

Similarly, the Armenia CO effectively utilized its two Funding Window allocations, (250,000 USD allocated in October 2022 and 500,000 USD initially allocated funds for ICS which later were repurposed to Armenia refugee response programming), to implement a range of integrated interventions that strengthened livelihoods, enhanced infrastructure, and promoted social cohesion in refugee-hosting communities. Support was provided to 72 refugee-led microbusinesses through tailored business training and grants, enabling beneficiaries to launch or scale income-generating activities. In parallel, 300 beehives were distributed to 150 trained individuals, creating sustainable sources of income and supporting rural resilience. To address energy and hygiene needs, 36 solar water heaters were installed in schools, medical centers, and other public buildings, benefiting over 4,000 people. These initiatives collectively contributed to improved self-sufficiency, environmental sustainability, and long-term community stability.

UNDP Armenia also engaged in mine action efforts as part of a broader United Nations initiative, including a joint assessment mission with UNICEF in February 2021.

Finally, in 2024, in response to severe flooding, UNDP led a Multi-Agency Initial Rapid Assessment (MIRA), and Post-Disaster Needs Assessment (PDNA), deploying an international expert to guide the process and inform early recovery planning. The finalized PDNA was presented at the national Green Platform meeting chaired by the Deputy Prime-Minister. UNDP's leadership was much appreciated at the highest level, further strengthening CO positioning as a partner of choice not only on priority development issues, but also in crisis settings.

4.3.3 Operational response support

UNDP's operational response was shaped by overlapping crises and constrained by the COVID-19 pandemic, which significantly impeded in-country activities during the initial response phase.

The institutionalized corporate special measures, which could have eased operational agility through e.g. fast-tracked procurement or flexible HR processes, would have allowed a more seamless and efficient response.

4.3.4 Coordination support

Efforts to maintain a balanced approach between the Armenia and Azerbaijan COs significantly shaped UNDP's response coordination during the crisis. Joint Crisis Board and CMST meetings were held with both COs, requiring a high level of political sensitivity given the complexity of the conflict. To remain impartial, UNDP sought to respond to both offices with equal attention. However, in retrospect, this approach may have introduced self-imposed operational constraints that limited flexibility and responsiveness. While both COs were affected by the crisis, their specific needs and contexts differed. The pursuit of balance may have inadvertently overlooked these differing realities on the ground. Furthermore, due to the political sensitivities involved, CMST meetings tended to have a stronger political focus than is typical. While this was necessary, it also highlighted the need for a dedicated space to address programmatic and operational issues. To fill this gap, the PSG was established, enabling more technical, implementation-focused discussions. Together, these coordination platforms helped maintain alignment between HQ, regional teams, and the COs.

UNDP's response in Armenia was embedded within broader UN system efforts, particularly through coordination mechanisms at the regional and inter-agency levels. The South Caucasus Working Group, convened by DPPA, was activated shortly after the outbreak of large-scale hostilities on 2 October 2020. This group brought together UN Resident Coordinators (RCs) from both Armenia and Azerbaijan, the International Peace and Development Advisor (PDA), as well as representatives from UNDP, OCHA, OHCHR, UNHCR, DCO, and other UN entities. Meeting regularly, the Working Group served as a platform for information exchange on agency-specific activities, joint risk assessment, and discussion on the UN's overall positioning in the evolving context.

In parallel, the possibility of conducting a Recovery and Peacebuilding Assessment (RPBA) in Armenia was discussed. The idea was first raised with government counterparts by the UN Resident

Coordinator's Office (RCO) in January 2021. Several informal discussions followed concerning the RPBA's potential content, scope, and timelines. A concept note was prepared, and in February 2022, the RCO shared Terms of Reference for a proposed RPBA scoping mission. However, there was no formal request from the Government to conduct the RPBA, and the Resident Coordinator later concluded that the situation in the country was not appropriate to pursue the assessment.

4.3.5 Communication support

At the onset of the crisis, it was evident that the Armenia CO required substantial communications support. It was important to balance the political sensitivity around the fact that UNDP simultaneously supported two country offices in conflict with each other, and that the response efforts also externally were perceived as impartial. Communications support and guidance was required to effectively position UNDP's response, maintain donor confidence, and ensure public visibility. Early discussions at the first Crisis Boards in October 2020 flagged this need, prompting engagement with the Bureau of External Relations and Advocacy (BERA) to provide technical assistance. As a response, one regional Crisis Communications Expert was deployed at the onset of the crisis, to help develop communications strategies for both the Armenian and Azerbaijani COs, as well as develop if-asked and key messages, while contributing to coordination of communications with DPPA. In addition, messaging protocols were issued, including guidance on the personal use of social media by staff, to support consistency and mitigate reputational risks.

Despite these efforts, the CO continued to face constraints in implementing a coordinated communications approach. Although it actively used social media to engage with local audiences, its official website lacked timely updates and did not reflect the scale or complexity of UNDP's crisis engagement. The UN BOA report noted that the lack of a dedicated crisis communications response page and intervention mapping limited UNDP's ability to visibly demonstrate leadership in the response, reinforcing perceptions of a 'business as usual' approach. While a communications strategy was in place, it lacked targeted audience segmentation, measurable objectives, and a unified narrative. The decentralized dissemination of content across platforms further diluted the overall impact. In a politically sensitive and donor-dependent setting, these limitations constrained UNDP's ability to communicate its value and mobilize broader support.

4.3.6 Resource mobilization support

Over the course of the Armenia Refugee Crisis response, UNDP Armenia mobilized/repurposed over USD 27 million from various donors including Japan, the EU, Sweden, Austria, and Norway.

Crisis response funding from the CB (total USD 1.75 million in the period from 2020 to 2024) were timely and closely linked to shifts in the crisis level and operational needs, providing critical support to enable rapid response, coordination, and recovery planning. These internal allocations enabled the Armenia CO to remain agile and responsive across multiple phases of the crisis. They also served as a catalyst for broader donor engagement, ultimately helping to mobilize over USD 27 million external funding over the four-year period.

Additionally, CB supported the CO to mobilize resources from donors including the UK. For instance, the UK established a UNDP-managed pooled funding mechanism for the South Caucasus and set up

a donor steering group to mobilize additional contributions. Despite outreach efforts, no other donors opted to join the pooled funds.

5. Findings and recommendations

The UNDP response to the Armenia crisis (2020–2024) offers valuable institutional and operational insights. Despite limited resources, thanks to targeted deployments, and adaptive coordination mechanisms, the Armenia CO sustained an effective crisis response under significant pressure. This chapter presents key findings and actionable recommendations to enhance UNDP’s preparedness, agility, and coherence in future crises.

The Armenia experience has already informed improvements across the organization, such as the institutionalization of special measures. However, several lessons remain critical to ensure continuous learning and accountability.

5.1 Key findings and lessons learned

Strategic Resource Mobilization

With a modest internal allocation of USD 1.75 million, UNDP Armenia successfully leveraged this seed funding to mobilize approximately USD 27 million from external donors, including the UK, Japan, the EU, Sweden, Austria, and Norway. This demonstrates the importance of flexible seed funding to unlock larger, sustained investments in crisis settings. For the Refugee Crisis in 2023, the Armenia CO rapidly designed a Crisis Offer with funding targets. This helped the CO mobilize resources.

Fit-for-Purpose Expert Deployments

Sixteen experts were deployed over the response period, aligning with the CO’s evolving needs. The timely, responsive nature of these deployments reinforced operational continuity and technical capacity, reaffirming the value of maintaining adaptable staffing mechanisms in protracted crises. However, gaps remained in the availability of profiles tailored to politically sensitive, middle-income settings.

Strengthening Crisis Communications

While crisis communications capacity was deployed at the onset of the crisis, communications capacity was insufficient to match the scale and complexity of the crisis. This experience catalyzed the development of comprehensive crisis communications packages and support systems, now institutionalized to improve narrative control in future emergencies.

Effective and Politically Sensitive Coordination

Efforts to coordinate support to both Armenia and Azerbaijan simultaneously introduced political sensitivities and operational constraints. Adjusting to more tailored coordination structures over time improved effectiveness. CMST and Crisis Board meetings often lacked focus and utility from the CO perspective. Coordination platforms grew too broad, limiting candid dialogue and slowing decision-making. The number of meetings (44 CMST meetings in 2 years) eventually strained engagement and reduced their overall effectiveness.

Operational Flexibility and Special Measures

The absence of early-activated corporate special measures (e.g., fast-tracked HR and procurement) hindered the CO's initial responsiveness. Since then, UNDP has institutionalized automatic rollout of these measures.

Preparedness and Contingency Planning

Despite warning signs, the scale and speed of the 2023 Refugee Crisis caught all stakeholders unprepared. However, objectively, the conditions were not in place for better preparedness. Despite that, the response was strong and adequate.

5.2 Actionable Recommendations

Enhance resource mobilization as per UN BOA Report Recommendation (BERA, Crisis Bureau, and RBEC)

- Develop a cohesive funding strategy at the onset of a crisis, enabling Country Offices experiencing emergencies to promptly prepare a well-structured Crisis Offer (i.e. Armenia Refugee Crisis Offer), including the following components:
 - Shared funding targets;
 - Donor mapping
 - A cohesive narrative aligned across CO, regional, and HQ levels

Deployments (Crisis Bureau)

- Diversify the ExpRes and SURGE rosters to include profiles with experience in politically sensitive, middle-income crisis settings

Strengthen Crisis Communications (Crisis Bureau and RBEC)

- Equip COs with pre-packaged communication tools and training for digital engagement.
- Ensure alignment with CO needs to sustain donor confidence and manage reputational risk.
- Establish clear visibility protocols, including a crisis-specific webpage and targeted messaging strategies (BOA Report Recommendation).

Streamline Coordination and Information-Sharing Mechanisms (Crisis Bureau and RBEC)

- Keep Crisis Boards strategic, leadership-focused, and outcome-oriented;
- Review and adapt CMST frequency, format, and participant lists based on country needs.
- Establish small, purpose-driven working groups (i.e. PSG) for targeted issues.
- Ensure meetings are focused on actionable outcomes, minimize overlap with other coordination channels, and gather regular feedback from COs to keep them relevant and efficient.

Integrate Political Guidance Early (RBEC and Crisis Bureau)

- Engage DPPA and other relevant UN partners proactively to ensure programming is politically informed.
- Introduce clear escalation protocols to request timely political analysis and support.
- Embed political risk analysis in early assessments and crisis response planning.

Use of Special Measures (Crisis Bureau and BMS)

- Ensure immediate use of newly institutionalized preapproved special measures upon crisis declaration.
- Provide training to COs and regional teams on the practical application of special operations and programmatic measures

Institutionalize Contingency Planning (Armenia CO and RBEC)

- Maintain active contingency plans and early warning monitoring between acute crisis phases.
- Regularly test preparedness mechanisms through simulations or tabletop exercises.
- Build crisis literacy within COs and regional hubs for anticipatory action.

Annex 1: List of crisis meetings

Meeting	Date	Crisis Level
Crisis Board #1	2 October 2020	L2 (Declared)
CMST #1	6 October 2020	L2
CMST #2	13 October 2020	L2
CMST #3	20 October 2020	L2
CMST #4	27 October 2020	L2
Crisis Board #2	2 November 2020	L3 (Escalated)
CMST #5	3 November 2020	L3
CMST #6	10 November 2020	L3
CMST #7	17 November 2020	L3
Crisis Board #3	20 November 2020	L3
CMST #8	24 November 2020	L3
CMST #9	1 December 2020	L3
CMST #10	4 December 2020	L3
CMST #11	8 December 2020	L3
CMST #12	15 December 2020	L3
CMST #13	22 December 2020	L3
CMST #14	12 January 2021	L3
CMST #15	19 January 2021	L3
CMST #16	26 January 2021	L3
CMST #17	2 February 2021	L3
CMST #18	9 February 2021	L3
CMST #19	16 February 2021	L3
CMST #20	23 February 2021	L3
CMST #21	2 March 2021	L3
CMST #22	9 March 2021	L3
CMST #23	16 March 2021	L3
CMST #24	30 March 2021	L3
CMST #25	13 April 2021	L3
CMST #26	20 April 2021	L3
CMST #27	27 April 2021	L3
CMST #28	11 May 2021	L3
CMST #29	25 May 2021	L3
CMST #30	8 June 2021	L3
CMST #31	6 July 2021	L3
CMST #32	27 July 2021	L3
CMST #33	31 August 2021	L3
CMST #34	21 September 2021	L3
CMST #35	19 October 2021	L3
CMST #36	16 November 2021	L3
CMST #37	14 December 2021	L3
CMST #38	18 January 2022	L3
CMST #39	22 February 2022	L3
CMST #40	15 March 2022	L3
CMST #41	22 April 2022	L3
CMST #42	17 May 2022	L3 (Decision to de-escalate to Crisis Level 2 by the AA decision as of 7 June 2022)
CMST #43	5 July 2022	L2
CMST #44	22 September 2022	L2
CMST #45	15 October 2024	Closure of Crisis Level with immediate effect.

Annex 2: Crisis Allocations

Funding mechanism	Purpose	Amount	Allocation date	Allocation expiry
TRAC3	Support to the South Caucasus Crisis	100,000 USD	14 October 2020	14 April 2021
TRAC3	Early recovery activities, response coordination, service delivery	500,000 USD	8 December 2020	4 July 2021
FW TRAC3	FW Emergency Response Focusing on Infrastructure Rehabilitation and Livelihood Recovery in Conflict-affected Communities	500,000 USD allocation (250,000 FW and 250,000 TRAC 3)	17 October 2022	17 October 2023 (FW)
FW	Initially allocated funds for ICS. Later repurposed to Armenia refugee response programming.	500,000 USD	19 June 2023	30 September 2023
TRAC3	Support to the response to the ARM refugee crisis.	100,000 USD	6 October 2024	6 April 2025
TRAC3	Flooding response. Needs assessment and Early Recovery in Lori and Tavush regions of Armenia	50,000 USD	3 June 2024	30 November 2024
Total		1.75 million USD		

Annex 3: Crisis Deployments

Title	Name	Modality	Start-date	End-date	Location
Regional Specialist, Development and Mine Action	Steinar Essen	ExpRes	17 August 2020	17 November 2020	Regional
Senior Conflict Prevention and Early Recovery Advisor	Slobodan Tadic	SURGE	19 October 2020	6 November 2020	Armenia
Regional Crisis Communication Advisor	Russell Geekie	ExpRes	29 October 2020	28 January 2021	Regional
Senior Conflict Prevention and Early Recovery Advisor	Charles Vern Huff	ExpRes	9 November 2020	5 February 2021	Armenia
Security Specialist	Gary Stephen Springer	ExpRes	21 November 2020	1 January 2021	Armenia
Digital Solutions Expert	Hosea Mitala	ExpRes	30 November 2020	15 January 2021	Armenia
Mine Action Advisory	Stephen Bryant	SURGE	1 December 2020	31 December 2020	Armenia
Senior Conflict Prevention and Early Recovery Advisor	Gregory Connor	SURGE	10 December 2020	10 January 2021	Armenia
Health Expert	Andrei Mecineanu	ExpRes	21 December 2020	31 January 2021	Armenia
Senior Conflict Prevention and Early Recovery Adviser	Jesse Garana	ExpRes	1 February 2021	30 April 2021	Armenia
Mine Action Assessment Mission for Armenia	Nils Rune Christensen	SURGE	7 February 2021	18 February 2021	Armenia
Information Management Officer	Patrice Ndji	SBP, DRC	19 April 2021	19 October 2021	Armenia
Early Recovery and Resilience Technical Lead /Advisor	Anna Mateeva	ExpRes	22 November 2021	21 February 2022	Armenia
Tandem Teams - IMO - Armenia	Davit Aghabekyan	UNV	3 January 2022	1 July 2022	Armenia
Agriculture, Food Systems and Livelihoods Technical Advisor	Bernard Francois Joseph Cartella	ExpRes	15 January 2022	14 April 2022	Armenia
International Expert for Post Disaster Needs Assessment (floods)	Graham Watson	ExpRes	21 June 2024	30 September 2024	Armenia

Annex 4: List of interviewees

Name	Title	Bureau	Date of interview
Konstantin Sokulskiy	Deputy Resident Representative	UNDP Armenia	9 th April 2025
Nazik Abdyeva	Strategy and Partnerships Specialist	RBEC	9 th April 2025 17 th June 2025
Steinar Essen	Global Advisor Mine Action	CB	28 th July 2025
Jonathan Zigrand	Chief of Strategy & Planning	RBEC	9 th April 2025 24 th June 2025
Mihaela Stojkoska	Chief of Strategy & Planning, RBEC / Former Deputy Resident Representative, UNDP Armenia	RBEC, former UNDP Armenia	24 th June 2025
Hiroshi Kuwata	Lead; Europe and Central Asia, and Arab States	CB	9 th April 2025 17 th June 2025 24 th June 2025 28 th July 2025
Sandra Kousa	Programme Analyst	CB	9 th April 2025 17 th June 2025 24 th June 2025 28 th July 2025

Annex 5: Matrix of main findings and recommendations

Item #	Response Area	Finding	Recommendation	Key Actions Required	Responsible
1	Strengthen Crisis Communications	At the onset of the crisis, communications capacity was insufficient to match the scale and complexity of the crisis.	Ensure crisis communication systems are fully prepared, well-resourced, and ready to scale quickly at the start of any crisis.	• Deploy tailored communications support early in crisis activation. • Equip COs with pre-packaged communication tools and training for digital engagement. • Establish clear visibility protocols, including a crisis-specific webpage and targeted messaging strategies (UN BOA Report Recommendation).	Crisis Bureau, RBEC
2	Enhance resource mobilization	With a modest internal allocation of USD 1.75 million (TRAC3 and FWs), UNDP Armenia successfully leveraged this seed funding to mobilize approximately USD 27 million from external donors. This demonstrates the importance of flexible seed funding to unlock larger, sustained investments in crisis settings.	Develop a cohesive funding strategy at the onset of a crisis, enabling Country Offices experiencing emergencies to promptly prepare a well-structured Crisis Offer (i.e. Armenia Refugee Crisis Offer),	• Establish a unified funding strategy from the outset, including: ○ Shared funding targets; ○ Donor mapping; ○ A cohesive narrative aligned across CO, regional, and HQ levels.	BERA, Crisis Bureau, and RBEC
3	Integrate Political Guidance Early	Efforts to coordinate support to both Armenia and Azerbaijan simultaneously introduced political sensitivities and operational constraints.	Integrate Political Guidance Early	• Engage DPPA and other relevant UN partners proactively to ensure programming is politically informed. • Introduce clear escalation protocols to request timely political analysis and support. • Embed political risk analysis in early assessments and crisis response planning.	Crisis Bureau and RBEC
4	Operational Flexibility and Special Measures	The absence of early-activated corporate special measures (e.g., fast-tracked HR and procurement) hindered the CO's	Use of Special Measures	• Ensure immediate use of newly institutionalized preapproved special measures upon crisis declaration.	Crisis Bureau and BMS

		initial responsiveness. Since then, UNDP has institutionalized automatic rollout of these measures.		• Provide training to COs and regional teams on the practical application of these tools.	
5	Streamline Coordination and Information-Sharing Mechanisms.	CMST and Crisis Board meetings often lacked focus and utility from the CO perspective. Coordination platforms grew too broad, limiting candid dialogue and slowing decision-making. The number of meetings (44 CMST meetings in 2 years), while well-intentioned, eventually strained engagement and reduced their overall effectiveness.	Adjusting to more tailored coordination structures over time to improve effectiveness of crisis response.	• Keep Crisis Boards strategic, leadership-focused, and outcome-oriented; • Review and adapt CMST frequency, format, and participant lists based on country needs. • Establish small, purpose-driven working groups (i.e. PSG) for targeted issues. • Ensure meetings are focused on actionable outcomes, minimize overlap with other coordination channels, and gather regular feedback from COs to keep them relevant and efficient.	Crisis Bureau and RBEC
6	Preparedness and Contingency Planning	Despite warning signs, the scale and speed of the 2023 Refugee Crisis caught all stakeholders unprepared. However, objectively, the conditions were not in place for better preparedness. Despite that, the response was strong and adequate.	Institutionalize Contingency Planning	• Maintain active contingency plans and early warning monitoring between acute crisis phases. • Regularly test preparedness mechanisms through simulations or tabletop exercises. • Build crisis literacy within COs and regional hubs for anticipatory action.	Armenia CO and RBEC
7	Deployments	Fifteen experts were deployed over the response period, aligning with the CO's evolving needs. The timely, responsive nature of these deployments reinforced operational continuity and technical capacity. However, gaps remained in the availability of profiles tailored to politically sensitive, middle-income settings.	Fit for purpose deployments	• Diversify the ExpRes and SURGE rosters to include profiles with experience in politically sensitive, middle-income crisis settings.	Crisis Bureau